

Relational Builder

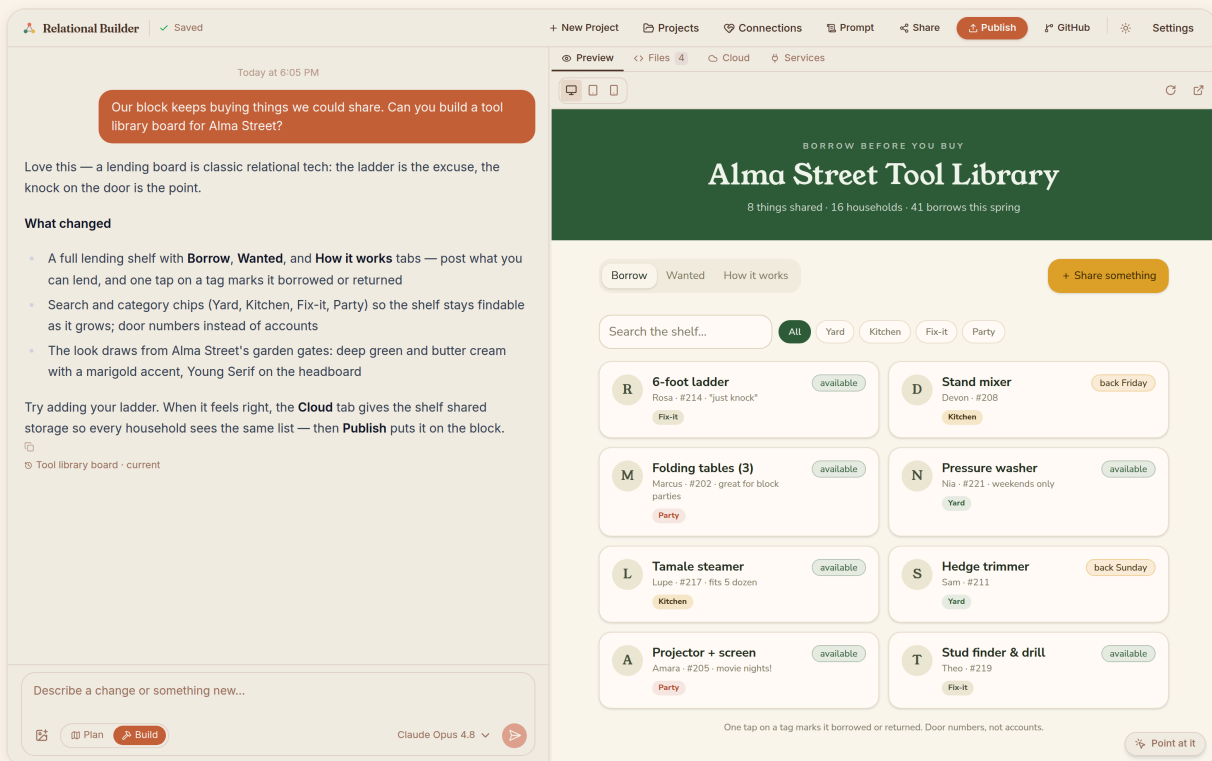
Describe what your neighborhood needs, in your own words, and build it together with AI — grounded in the relational tech commons, offered back to the commons.

An open-source builder for relational technology · relationalbuilder.org · July 2026

The short version

- **Say it in your own words.** A builder types what their neighborhood needs; AI writes real software — full React apps on the Builder's own component kit — while they watch it run in a live preview, every version saved as they go.
- **One click publishes** to free community hosting, with a built-in way for neighbors to leave notes back.
- **Every build starts from the commons** — 365 tools, stories, and recipes with lineage attached, shaped by the five relational tech principles.
- **Free for invited builders.** Sign in with a 6-digit email code and build on frontier models — Claude Opus 4.8 plans and makes the first build; Sonnet 5 handles quick edits. No API key, no credit card, no signup maze.
- **Finished builds flow back:** distilled into travel-ready prompts, offered to the commons consent-first, credited by name.

Relational Builder is a web-based app builder for the tools neighborhoods actually need: the calendar people can find, the lending library for the block, the meal train for a recovering neighbor, the flyer for the laundromat corkboard. It is not a general-purpose app factory — every conversation searches what real neighborhoods have already learned, so each build starts from a place, not a blank page.

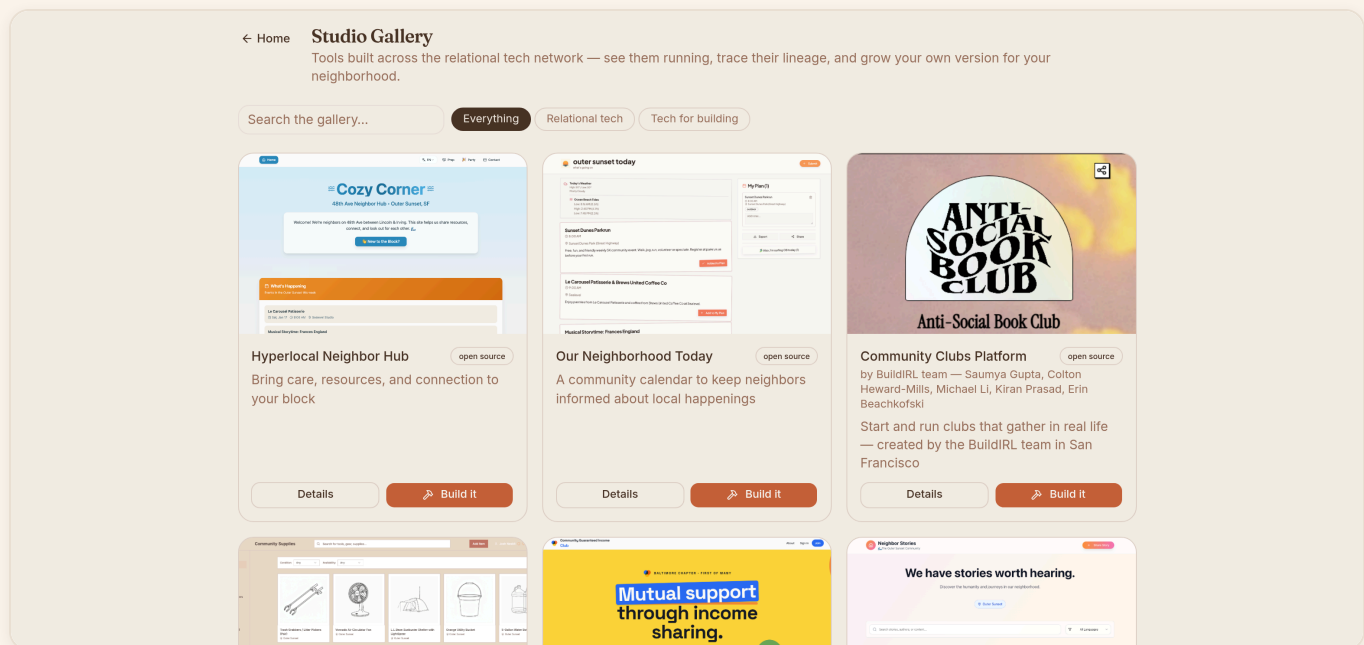


The loop in one screen A neighbor asked for a tool-lending board for their street; the app runs live in the preview as the conversation shapes it.

A different kind of builder

AI app builders are suddenly everywhere. What makes this one relational is everything wrapped around the code.

- **Vision before code.** Planning is the default for a new build: the Builder explores the idea first — your place, your people, commons examples by name — asking one question at a time before anything gets made.
- **Real apps, exportable apps.** Builds are full React apps on the Builder's shadcn-aligned component kit and design tokens; the preview is the same bundle that publishes, so what you watched is what neighbors get.
- **Point at it.** Click any element in the running app and describe the change in plain words. Click text and just type the new wording.
- **Hosting with a return channel.** Free RTP hosting for finished apps, with privacy-friendly visit counts and a built-in “leave a note” widget for neighbors.
- **Paper counts too.** Print-ready flyers, posters, and newsletters with real page sizes and tear-off tabs — some of the best relational tech goes on a corkboard.
- **Ready for a room.** Invitation links that open the door, 6-digit email sign-in codes, and rate limits tuned for one venue's WiFi — a fifty-person build jam goes from the door to building in minutes.
- **The commons in every prompt.** Semantic search across the whole library on every message — patterns, stories, and recipes from the network inform each build.
- **Studios as first-class homes.** Builders belong to studios (Relational Tech Studio, Thread in Baltimore, yours next); a studio's principles layer onto every build.
- **Waits that build relationships.** While a first build runs, the chat asks: who else cares about this? Who spreads the word? The sharing plan saves into the project.
- **Community Cloud.** One click gives any app a free shared data store with neighbor email-code sign-in — no database accounts, no SQL.
- **Prompts as seeds.** Every build distills into a self-contained prompt — versioned, shareable by link, replantable in another neighborhood with credit traveling along.
- **Grows with the builder.** Apps can add their own AI features, an admin page for editing without chat, and a personal design system that makes each builder's apps feel like their place.



The Studio Gallery “Build it” doesn't clone code — it distills the tool into a place-adaptable prompt, so each neighborhood grows its own version.

Why it matters

Community work is 90 percent presence and relationship. Technology is the last 10.

What AI changes is who can do that 10 percent. A year ago, a neighborhood tool meant finding (and usually paying) a developer, or settling for a platform built for everyone and fitted to no one. Now the distance between “someone should make...” said out loud at a block party and a working tool neighbors are using is one conversation. Relational Builder exists to make sure that new capability lands relationally: grounded in principles, accountable to a place, feeding a commons no one can enclose — instead of arriving as one more extractive platform with a neighborhood-shaped logo.

The details are deliberate. Free community access means the person who hosts the potluck — not just the person with the API key — can build. Consent-first sharing and steward review mean the commons grows with care. Lineage on everything means credit travels, and remixing is honored as the way good tools spread: locality to locality, keeping what fits, changing what doesn't.

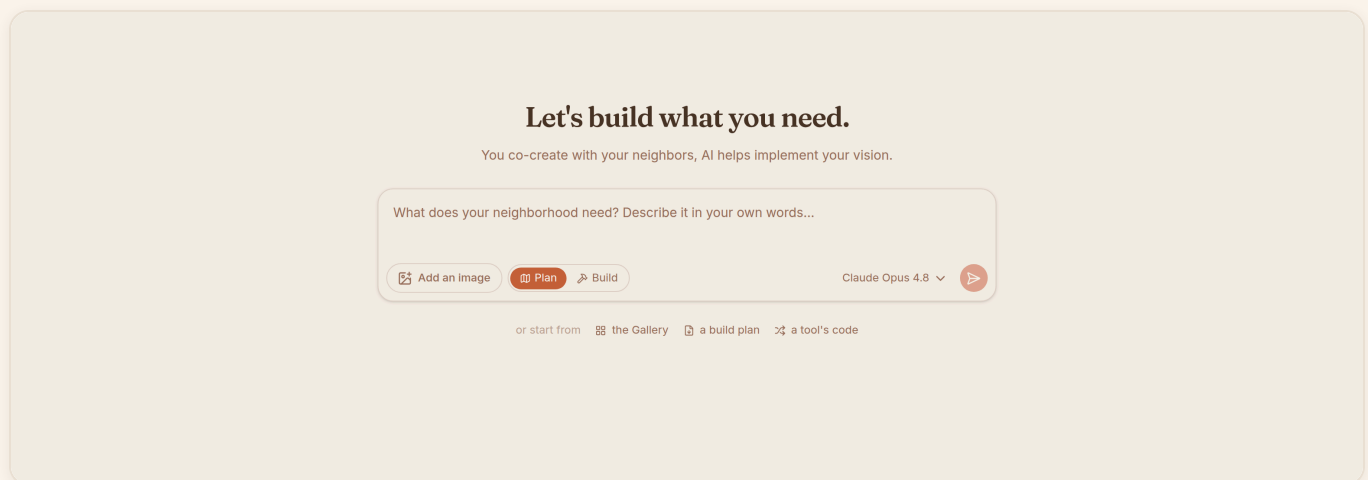
Millions building

The workshop for a new kind of work.

Our white paper, *We can build what we need*, describes a new role — the local relational technologist — and an experiment: 200 fully funded builders across San Francisco, Baltimore, and rural America, each proving the role can pay for itself close to home. Relational Builder is that role's workshop. It is how a technologist directs AI to write software overnight after a day of community work; how the hundred neighbors around them co-create instead of just consuming; and how the recipes travel, so a meal train grown on one street replants in Novi Sad, Tampere, or Hialeah without anyone scheduling a call.

Prove one loop. Run it in thousands of neighborhoods. Open it to millions of people building what they need, with the people around them.

Every piece of the Builder points at that scale: prompts as seeds so tools spread without dependence, studios so organizations can host their own gardens, open licenses so nothing gets enclosed, and a commons that gets richer with every build offered back. The software is open source, the practice is teachable, and the door is open — anyone can request an account, and a real person answers.



The screenshot shows the Relational Builder web interface. At the top, it says "Let's build what you need." followed by the subtitle "You co-create with your neighbors, AI helps implement your vision." Below this is a large text input field with the placeholder "What does your neighborhood need? Describe it in your own words...". Under the input field are three buttons: "Add an image" (with a plus icon), "Plan" (with a document icon), and "Build" (with a play icon). To the right of these buttons is a dropdown menu showing "Claude Opus 4.8" and a play button. At the bottom of the interface, there is a row of links: "or start from", "the Gallery", "a build plan", and "a tool's code".

The front door “What does your neighborhood need? Describe it in your own words.” Plan first or build straight away — or start from the Gallery, a build plan, or a tool's code.

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